

About AI and the Environment

Posted by u/ThatCapMan • 0 points • 12 comments

I think that in the majority of cases when AI and the environment are mentioned in the same sentence, it's always water usage.

I want you to know that it's... kind of wrong information.

It is very simple to make your calculations for water-usage larger or smaller - **you could account for** all the **background queries** made by an AI, for example, all of those **background processes** made by just one query, you could account for **all of the training** it took for the AI that's being used in this example to get to where it is... you could also account for all of the **power-generation** required to run it all.

A lot of water is also used **to create the components** for AI data centers and other things dedicated or related to the production and training of AI, **like** some various **chips**

A lot of things have some negative effects on the environment but, at the same time that we need to seek better renewable technologies and also implement them, completely phasing out fossil fuels is really inconvenient, and there are valid reasons for its usage.

Do not seek extremes for the purposes of the environment, **people** still **need** to use **cars**, even though **it would be** much **better** for the environment for everyone **to use public transportation** \- **a car is still essential** for a lot of reasons. In the same way that you could seek out that extreme, you could then very easily go and say "Well why do we even need to drive to places" and while making things more easily accessible within your area of living, the other part is that big companies are also using transportation for their own purposes - like if you've ever gotten something shipped, for example. The more you err on the extremes, the further you can get. You can then go into details about how people are environmental jerks for not getting environmentally perfect jobs, or don't eat environmentally perfectly and it just... bogs down the movement.

The people who are acting as the **consumers** of AI and creating queries **aren't** equivalently responsible for the resource requirements.

People shouldn't be using AI because AI can be a **shortcut to an answer**, it can be a **shortcut to schoolwork** (though y'know some assignments are just bloat and I get it but

there is important schoolwork that this is lazily used for), **it can get things wrong**, and AI generated art isn't good/is a problem because **You can sell it off as though you made it** A lot of it (or, this used to be the case) is **very easily recognizable and just doesn't look right**, you see it everywhere so you start to not like it I personally really hate the most usual ways it comes out looking, I can't escape from it It makes mistakes in the image itself **The training of it wasn't done ethically** **You now have a moment where you actually question if a piece of art you're looking at on the internet is real or AI generated** It's just a shortcut There's certainly other reasons that just aren't coming up to the top of my head right now, but I think I got the important ones. Even in writing this, I know that my use of **and** - and boldening text might click to some people as "Mmm AI..." and I'm internally a bit concerned with anything I type out, that it will be mistaken for AI by someone.

My biggest thing though when it comes to talking about AI and the reason I'm making this post for is...

Please do not co-opt environmental care for your purposes.

I have spent quite a few years in environmental schooling and spaces. A lot of discourse regarding AI is in regards to people using it, it's not their fault that them using a service does something intangible to them - it's much more tangible to discuss why AI is bad, without talking about the environment.

I saw this trend that came up with a few people I've known; who understandably didn't like AI art and, all of a sudden, started showing interest in the environment. People who weren't very interested in STEM, who while they may have surely cared for the environment just out of personal ethics, started talking a lot about how **this thing that's insulting to them is bad for the environment**.

It's just finding another thing to add on to it to justify hate for it. You can't get through to people by applying an ethical understanding for art, so you apply a separate ethical understanding for the environment.

It rubs me the wrong way.

Comments

When it is causing some towns to lack clean drinking water near to the data centers, how do we tackle that? That is a direct human cost of AI and the environment.

u/ThatCapMan • 1 points • 2025-12-26 19:43 UTC

Hey, buddy, guess what.

So is large-scale bitcoin mining.

When you take on a subject and then find out that said subject that you **don't like** has **issues**, you forget the fact that those issues ****aren't**** under the umbrella of that subject and are instead under a whole separate category of societal problems.

You also have to consider in **which** places those data centers **are** taking up drinking water, simply generalizing it as "Oh they're consuming so much water" won't really fix things, if you can't take a moment to pinpoint in what areas these are and establish activism for them.

In your endeavour towards shrugging off AI, did you take into account large-scale bitcoin mining facilities, which use up water and a lot of similar or the same components as AI data centers, and how those crypto farms cause noise pollution, did you take into account how creating the electricity that runs these farms **also** takes up water consumption, though is a different type of water, did you take in any activism that regards that data centers should switch to a separate source of water than communal drinking water?

I'm just saying, if you're going to be caring about the environment, don't be using it as a crutch for your agenda.

u/Scorpion451 • 2 points • 2025-12-26 23:22 UTC

The problem is that you're trying to oversimplify things into simple single-issue situations, when in reality things are interconnected and overlapping.

You're dancing around the idea when you look at the problem of defining how much water these facilities are using- and the answer is that you have to zoom out to include all of it, and all of the problems that it represents a symptom of.

LLMs and Crypto are only two of the players behind the data center wildcatting, but the data centers themselves are just the newest major contributor to the per-existing problem of rural water depletion and contamination- for decades, corporations have been buying up cheap land in regions with weak water regulation (especially in arid regions where this was intended to benefit ranchers and subsistence farmers), setting up resorts and golf courses, mega-farms for climate-inappropriate crops, inland aquaculture facilities, power plants for distant cities, and so on, draining the reservoirs and aquifers from under the surrounding communities and tainting what's left.

On the other end, the environmental impacts are not limited to just the water- the added grid loads they create are pushing fossil fuel power plants once slated to be decommissioned into extended service and their insane demand for advanced chips encourage "fines are just operating costs"-type expansion of rare earth mining.

Zooming out again, the environmental harms directly affect the lives and health of those surrounding rural communities, and in addition drive up land prices, hog internet bandwidth, overload aging power grids and infrastructure, and use corporate money to ensure that any repairs or improvements benefit the facility first and most.

And this is all before we get into the fundamental issues of these not-really-AI programs having yet to produce anything but a lot of rehashed internet residue that impresses the sort of executives best put in a corner office and kept occupied by shiny objects and thumbnail images of monkeys.

u/ardarian262 • 1 points • 2025-12-27 02:03 UTC

Absolutely all this. It really does not help that "well the water cycle" realistically means that any evaporated water from cooling that isn't contaminated is also going elsewhere (likely to fall as rain over mountains several hundred miles away) and thus exporting the drinking water of these areas with the plants to areas with already robust aquifers and reservoirs.

u/ardarian262 • 2 points • 2025-12-26 20:49 UTC

I am also against bitcoin mining for the same reason. Crypto is a waste of energy and water.

My solution is removing the AI data centers from vulnerable areas and not replacing them. Because they are bad for the people of those communities and actively and directly harming them. The water leaving the local ecosystem and not being replaced is the reason multiple towns have died once the data centers are put there.

u/Aggressive-Dog2793 • 3 points • 2025-12-26 14:23 UTC

dawg im just here for the memes 🤡

u/ThatCapMan • 4 points • 2025-12-26 14:25 UTC

Yea... sorry about that, big shot.

u/Aggressive-Dog2793 • 1 points • 2025-12-26 14:26 UTC

can u maybe do a tl dr tho

u/ThatCapMan • 3 points • 2025-12-26 14:33 UTC

There!

u/Aggressive-Dog2793 • 3 points • 2025-12-26 15:05 UTC

Tyyy

u/ThatCapMan • 5 points • 2025-12-26 14:28 UTC

I think so...

u/Aggressive-Dog2793 • 2 points • 2025-12-26 14:29 UTC

o btw i remember my sister stopped using GPT cus it was bad for the environment